

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cybersecurity English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For security analysts, SOC staff, incident responders, security engineers, GRC specialists, identity teams, vulnerability managers, and security leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

abuse case

A description of how someone could misuse a system to cause an unwanted outcome.

alert

A notification that an event or condition may need attention.

attack surface

Set of systems, interfaces, identities, and entry points an attacker could attempt to exploit.

audit evidence

Records, observations, or other information used to support an audit conclusion.

compensating control

An alternative safeguard used to address risk when another control cannot be applied as intended.

containment

Action intended to limit the spread or effect of a problem while it is addressed.

control

A process, approval, check, or technical safeguard designed to reduce risk.

CVE

Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures identifier used to reference a publicly known cybersecurity vulnerability.

CVSS

Common Vulnerability Scoring System, a standardized method for expressing the severity and characteristics of a vulnerability.

exploitability

How feasible it is for an attacker to take advantage of a vulnerability.

false positive

A result that flags a condition as present when it is absent under the stated definition.

forensics

The collection and examination of evidence to understand an event.

IAM

Identity and access management: processes and systems for managing identities and permissions.

incident

Unplanned event that disrupts service, safety, quality, security, operations, or expected performance.

investment ask

A specific request for funding or resources, supported by a stated purpose and rationale.

least privilege

Providing only the access needed for an authorized task or role.

maturity

The degree to which a process or capability is developed and consistently practiced.

MFA

Multi-factor authentication: verifying identity using more than one distinct type of authentication factor.

phishing

Deceptive communication intended to induce disclosure, access, or another harmful action.

privileged account

An account with elevated permissions beyond ordinary user access.

ransomware

Malicious software used to deny access to data or systems and demand payment.

RBAC

Role-based access control: assigning permissions according to defined roles.

remediation

Work to correct a problem or reduce its effects; in environmental work, addressing contamination.

reporting culture

Shared expectations that encourage people to raise concerns and report relevant events.

residual risk

The risk remaining after controls or other responses are applied.

risk acceptance

An authorized decision to retain a stated risk under specified conditions.

security awareness

Understanding relevant security risks and how to respond through appropriate processes.

SIEM

Security information and event management: tools that collect and analyze security-related event data.

social engineering

Manipulating people into revealing information or taking actions that compromise security.

threat actor

A person or group capable of pursuing actions that threaten a system or organization.

threat model

A structured description of possible threats to a system and relevant design protections.

trust boundary

A point where data or activity crosses between areas with different trust or access assumptions.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Security Triage and Alert Investigation

A monitoring tool raises an alert about a privileged account. The analyst has not determined whether the activity is authorized.

The alert indicates activity that needs investigation. It does not by itself establish a compromise. I'll record the observed event and the questions needed to determine its significance.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Incident Response and Containment

A response team receives a suspected incident. The initial report contains a timestamp and affected service but no confirmed cause.

The report identifies the affected service and timestamp; the cause is unconfirmed. Please acknowledge the handoff and use the response process to coordinate investigation and any containment decision.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Vulnerability Management

Two vulnerabilities have similar severity scores, but one affects an exposed service and the other an isolated test system.

The scores are similar, but exposure and operational context differ. Let's compare those factors and the available evidence before presenting a remediation priority to the responsible team.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Identity, Access, and Least Privilege

A vendor requests a shared privileged account for support. The organization has a controlled access-review process.

Could you specify the tasks, users, and access period required? We'll submit the request through the access-review process so the appropriate scope and accountability can be assessed.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Threat Modeling and Secure Design

A threat-model discussion lists technologies but does not identify the data flows or trust boundaries.

Which data crosses each boundary, and who can interact with it? Let's map those flows so the discussion connects possible threats to the actual design.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Governance, Risk, and Compliance

An audit action is marked closed because a policy was written. Evidence that the control operates is still missing.

The policy is complete, but evidence of operation is still outstanding. I'll distinguish the documented design from implementation evidence before we report the action's status.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Security Awareness and Phishing

A staff member reports a suspicious message and worries about being blamed. The report has not yet been assessed.

Thank you for reporting it. Please use the designated channel to share the relevant details. We'll focus on assessing the message and the next steps rather than making assumptions about blame.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Executive Risk Briefings

A budget proposal describes many technical weaknesses but never explains their possible business effects.

I'll connect each issue to the affected service, plausible consequence, and proposed response. That will help leaders compare the investment request with the risk it is intended to address.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Cybersecurity English

Professional audience: security analysts, SOC staff, incident responders, security engineers, GRC specialists, identity teams, vulnerability managers, and security leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Security Triage and Alert Investigation

Original fictional case: A monitoring tool raises an alert about a privileged account. The analyst has not determined whether the activity is authorized.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

Vocabulary: SIEM: Security information and event management: tools that collect and analyze security-related event data. / alert: A notification that an event or condition may need attention. / false positive: A result that flags a condition as present when it is absent under the stated definition. / privileged account: An account with elevated permissions beyond ordinary user access.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The alert indicates activity that needs investigation. It does not by itself establish a compromise. I'll record the observed event and the questions needed to determine its significance.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level